

DESIGN TOKENS PRO

The Guide

Taxonomy, naming, architecture, themes, and the life of a token. Eight chapters.

Contents

01 Basics

- What is a design token
- Tokens, variables, and styles
- Anatomy of a token
- Why tokens exist
- Benefits for a design system

02 Elements of Token Name

- Category
- Property
- Concept and purpose
- Scale and variant
- Choosing only what you need

03 Tokens Architecture

- Token tiers and layers
- Primitive, semantic, and component tokens
- References and aliases
- Organizing token files
- Scaling the architecture

04 Taxonomy & Naming Convention

- Why taxonomy matters
- Building a shared vocabulary
- Naming patterns that scale
- Working with your team
- Evolving the convention

05 Compound Tokens

- Single vs compound tokens
- Typography tokens
- Shadow and effect tokens
- When to use a compound token
- Platform considerations

06 Themes and Color Modes

Theme vs color mode

Light and dark

Multi-brand theming

Organizing theme files

Implementation strategies

07 Lifecycle of a Token

Creating a token

Storage and source of truth

Transformation and delivery

Consumption across tools

Change and deprecation

08 Documenting Tokens

What to document

Where documentation lives

Usage guidelines

Tracking changes

Helping teams adopt tokens

Basics

Learn the design tokens foundations: what they are, their function, their appearance, and the advantages they bring to a project or design system.

The parts of a token name are covered in [Elements of Token Name](#). How those names are structured across a system is covered in [Tokens Architecture](#).

What is a design token

Tokens, variables, and styles

Anatomy of a token

Why tokens exist

Benefits for a design system

Elements of Token Name

What are the elements that make up the name of a token, being careful to choose only those that are needed.

How these elements become a shared convention is covered in [Taxonomy & Naming Convention](#).

Category

Property

Concept and purpose

Scale and variant

Choosing only what you need

Tokens Architecture

Learn how to structure and organize design tokens for scalable design systems.

Themes that sit on top of this structure are covered in [Themes and Color Modes](#).

Token tiers and layers

Primitive, semantic, and component tokens

References and aliases

Organizing token files

Scaling the architecture

Taxonomy & Naming Convention

Learn how to create a taxonomy, why it's important, and how to set up a shared naming convention with your team and stakeholders.

Why taxonomy matters

Building a shared vocabulary

Naming patterns that scale

Working with your team

Evolving the convention

Compound Tokens

Dive into the topic of compound tokens. Understand what they are, how they differ from single tokens, and their role in complex designs.

Single vs compound tokens

Typography tokens

Shadow and effect tokens

When to use a compound token

Platform considerations

Themes and Color Modes

Learn the strategies for managing themes within either a single project or across multiple projects. Gain insights into organizing these themes and implementing them effectively.

Theme vs color mode

Light and dark

Multi-brand theming

Organizing theme files

Implementation strategies

Lifecycle of a Token

Explore the lifecycle, storage, and usage of design tokens across tools, vital for their effective management and a streamlined design process.

How to record that lifecycle for the team is covered in [Documenting Tokens](#).

Creating a token

Storage and source of truth

Transformation and delivery

Consumption across tools

Change and deprecation

Documenting Tokens

Learn how to document design tokens effectively. Record and track how each token is used and changed, ensuring your team can use them effectively.

What to document

Where documentation lives

Usage guidelines

Tracking changes

Helping teams adopt tokens